FINASTERIDE

Women must not handle crushed tablets

Halves PSA

CHEMICAL NAME N-(1,1-dimethylethyl)-3-oxo-4-aza-5α-androst-1-ene-17β-carboxamide

CLASS 5α-reductase inhibitor (type II)

TRADE NAMES Proscar (5 mg) · Propecia (1 mg) · Finast

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Benign prostatic hyperplasia (large prostate) — reduces size, risk of retention and surgery.
- Male-pattern hair loss (androgenetic alopecia); 1 mg.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Inhibits **5α-reductase type II** → ↓ conversion of testosterone to dihydrotestosterone (DHT) by ~70% → prostate shrinks (~20–30%).
- Lowers PSA by ~50% (double PSA value for cancer screening).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** once daily with or without food.
- Full effect after 6–12 months.
- Pregnant women should not handle crushed/broken tablets.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Erectile dysfunction, decreased libido, reduced ejaculate.
- Breast tenderness, gynaecomastia.
- Rash.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Depression, suicidal thoughts (rare).
- Male breast cancer (rare).
- Persistent sexual dysfunction after stopping (reported).
- Possible ↑ high-grade prostate cancer detection.

DOSAGES

- **BPH:** 5 mg once daily (often with tamsulosin).
- **Hair loss:** 1 mg once daily.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** DHT falls within 24 h; prostate shrinks over 6 months.
- Metabolised in liver (CYP3A4).
- Excreted in faeces and urine. **t½:** 6–8 h.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Women and children (teratogenic; male fetal genital abnormalities).
- Hypersensitivity.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- No significant interactions.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Baseline PSA; interpret PSA ×2 on treatment.
- Assess urinary symptoms over months.
- Educate female carers about tablet handling.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Benefit takes up to 6 months.
- Sexual side effects may occur — discuss with doctor.
- Report breast lumps, nipple discharge, low mood.
- Use condoms if partner pregnant (small amounts in semen).

KEY POINTS

- 5α-reductase inhibitor; shrinks prostate.
- Halves PSA.
- 5 mg daily; effect after 6 months.
- Teratogenic — women must not handle crushed tablets.

SOURCES CHECKED **[696]** Finasteride 1 mg film-coated tablets (UK SmPC) **[697]** Finasteride, oral (US label) **[698]** Finasteride, oral (US label, Aphena Pharma)

Full references p. 432–457